to Chandrababu Naidu, whose Telugu Desam Party won 16 seats in Andhra Pradesh, in influence. Unlike in 2019, when the JD(U) won 16 seats but was offered only one ministerial berth—which he declined, Nitish can now leverage his position to drive a hard bargain and seek key portfolios, including the coveted railways ministry, alongside a special package for Bihar. Former JD(U) president Lalan Singh and Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Kumar Jha are strong contenders for induction into the Union cabinet.

WHAT WORKED FOR NITISH

While many had dismissed Nitish's return to the BJP this January as madness, it now seems there was a method to it. Far from being another flip-flop, it was a calculated move. For one, the JD(U) has always done well in the company of BJP, their combined vote share of 39 per cent, eight percentage points higher than the RJD-Congress this time. Then, there was the frustration building up with INDIA, whose differently moving parts were weighing down the whole. Nitish, the lead writer of that script, found himself being denied due recognition not just for this role but also for handing the Opposition a narrative of a national caste census with a survey in his own state.

With his options fast running out, Nitish chose pragmatism over ideological fidelity, even if many saw his return to the NDA as a leap into oblivion, convinced the BJP would wean away his voter base and hang him out to dry. The BJP's own state unit was reluctant to accept Nitish again; state BJP president Samrat Choudhary had vowed he would keep his turban on until Nitish was ousted. Within the JD(U), there were murmurs that breaking off with Tejaswi would mean forfeiting the RJD's not inconsiderable 32 per cent Muslim-Yadav support base.

However, feedback from the ground convinced Nitish that any cohesion between his Extremely Backward Class (EBC) voters and the dominant Yadavs in the RJD would remain a pipe dream. The EBCs, a diverse tapestry of Bihar's smaller communities that constitute 36 per cent of Bihar's population, have been unwavering in their support for Nitish. Also the Mahadalits among Scheduled Castes and the caste-neutral constituency of women, whom Nitish has wooed assiduously over the years. The BJP, in turn, would bring its elite caste and Vaishya following to the table, while Paswan and Manjhi would assure the votes of their communities. Add BJP's formidable election machinery and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's widespread appeal, and the NDA seemed set to repeat its 39-seat tally of 2019.

Bihar BJP leaders will now have to bow to Nitish's wishes , and he is likely to remain at the helm as the NDA prepares for the assembly election in 2025

WHY BJP FELL SHORT

It was not to be. The BJP's overdependence on Modi proved to be its undoing; as did its failure to address dissatisfaction among core voters. In Aurangabad, the decision to repeat Sushil Kumar Singh, despite local resentment, backfired. If the BJP did secure 12 seats, it was mainly because Nitish's voter base supported all NDA candidates. The untimely demise of Sushil Modi had also left a leadership void that deputy CMs Samrat Choudhary and Vijay Kumar Sinha had been unable to fill, particularly in inspiring their respective Kushwaha and Bhumihar communities to vote for the NDA.

WHY TEJASWI DID NOT DELIVER

Be it narrative or attempts to broadbase the RJD's vote bank beyond M-Y, effort was one thing Tejaswi did not skimp on. In the end, however, he could not convert smart strategy into votes or effect a shift in voter allegiance.

Instead, the ruling combine's narrative of a "return to jangal raj", alluding to the 15-year rule of the RJD from 1990 to 2005, worked against him. Especially as Nitish held up his own administration as a contrast to those "dark ages", constantly reminding the electorate, especially the youth who had no experience of it, of the regression in store for them if they voted the Opposition. In the end, the faithful went with Sushasan Babu, ensuring he remains a part of Bihar's constantly evolving political theatre.

Indeed, the altered Lok Sabha dynamics are likely to strengthen Nitish's hand in government back home too. The JD(U) may have only 44 MLAs compared to the BJP's 78, but Nitish is set to regain the control and authority he enjoyed prior to the 2020 assembly polls. Deputy CMs Choudhary and Sinha, as well as other BJP leaders, will now have to bow to his wishes, given his crucial role not only in state politics but also in the stability of the central government. The Lok Sabha results should also quell any speculation about change in leadership. His partymen are adamant that Nitish stays at the helm as the NDA prepares for the 2025 assembly polls. Especially as Lalu's son will be hot on their heels and people vote differently in a state election. Unless of course the election is advanced, and Nitish gains from the current momentum. ■